

Raptor Ride bike race supports center for birds of prey

BY JENNY DRABBLE
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What started with a bottle of wine has led to an annual bike race that raises money for birds of prey.

The Raptor Ride — which includes 20-, 40- and 67-mile routes through the Yadkin Valley — was established after a pair of Red Shoulder Hawks living in his yard provided David Blackwell, the owner of Brandon Hills Vineyard in Yadkinville, with the inspi-

ration for a new wine.

Naming the bottle Raptor Red after the hawks, he decided to create an event to raise money and awareness for the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville, a rehabilitation center for orphaned injured birds of prey. The fourth annual event will start and finish at the vineyard Saturday.

To kick off the event, the Carolina Raptor Center will release a Red Shoulder Hawk, an orphaned raptor from Asheville, at the vine-

yard at 8 a.m.

"It's really exciting to see the raptors up close and hear the wind off their wings as they take off into the wild," Blackwell said.

The Red Shoulder Hawk will be the ninth bird to be released on the 100-acre property, which includes the vineyard.

"It never gets old seeing the birds released here, and we're so happy to support such a great cause," Blackwell said.

Blackwell donates \$1 to

the Carolina Raptor Center for the sale of each bottle of Raptor Red, which has become one of the vineyard's best selling wines and features a hawk on the label.

The nonprofit center, which took in more than 1,000 birds in 2012, spends between \$500 and \$700 on each bird to get it strong enough to be released back into the wild.

Entry fees and corporate sponsors for the ride will go toward helping birds at the nonprofit center.

With 200 cyclists signed up already and expecting more to register on the day of the event, Blackwell said he is confident that he will be able to raise \$6,000.

The previous three events raised a total of \$12,000 for the center.

Blackwell said the Raptor Ride also brings awareness to the group. The center will set up an information tent at the event and bring an orphaned great horned owl that cannot be released into the wild because of

human imprinting.

"Human imprinting means the bird goes to humans for food instead of looking for its own food, so would have a hard time surviving in the wild," Blackwell said. "By spreading awareness, we can let people know how to handle injured or orphaned birds and where to bring them."

For information or to register, go to www.brandondhillsvineyard.com.

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